Role Swap

Civic Skill: Empathy | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) & Outcome 4 (Learning) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will use role reversal in dramatic play to practise inhabiting another person's experience and to notice how the same situation feels different depending on your position.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can try playing a different role from my usual one.
- I can describe what it felt like to be in the other position.
- I can say something that surprised me about the other person's experience.

MATERIALS

- A simple dramatic play scenario set up in advance (e.g., a 'café' with customer and waiter roles, or a 'hospital' with patient and carer roles)
- Role labels or simple props to mark each role (e.g., an apron for the waiter, a blanket for the patient)
- Picture book: 'Each Kindness' by Jacqueline Woodson (or 'Last Stop on Market Street' by Matt de la Peña)
- Paper for drawing 'what it felt like'

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. BOOK OPENER (6 min): Read 'Each Kindness.' Stop before the ending. 'How do you think Maya felt, waiting to be included? And how do you think Chloe felt, when she looked back?' Sit with the uncertainty — don't resolve it too quickly.

2. ROLE SWAP INTRODUCTION (3 min): Set up two roles in the dramatic play space. Explain the activity: 'First, you'll play one role for a few minutes. Then we swap. After both turns, we'll share what surprised us.'

3. ROUND 1 (5 min): Children play their first role. Educator circulates, narrating what they observe: 'I notice the waiter is having to remember a lot of things. I notice the customer is doing a lot of waiting.'

4. ROLE SWAP (1 min): Signal the swap clearly. 'Everyone stop! Swap your role. You are now someone different.'

5. ROUND 2 (5 min): Children play the second role. Educator focuses questions on contrast: 'Is this different from before? What's harder? What's easier?'

6. DEBRIEF CIRCLE (5 min): 'What surprised you about the other role? What did you understand about that person that you didn't understand before?' Record exact quotes for documentation.

EXTENSIONS

- Try the role swap in a conflict scenario — after a real disagreement in the room, offer: 'Can we swap and try it from the other side?'
- Introduce a third role: an observer who reports what they noticed about each person's experience
- Write or draw a split-page: 'From my side it felt like ___ / From their side it might have felt like ___'

ASSESSMENT

- Observation: Can the child stay in role and describe the experience from that position, rather than their own?
- Key question to ask individually: 'What was it like being the ___? What was the hardest part?'
- Note: children who say 'I didn't like it' are demonstrating empathy — they noticed the difficulty of the other role

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Did any children struggle to see the other role as legitimate? What does that tell you about their current stage of perspective-taking?
- How did the book opener shape the children's engagement with the role swap?
- Where in your daily routine could you introduce small role swaps — e.g., who leads the line, who chooses first?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) & Outcome 4 (Learning). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.